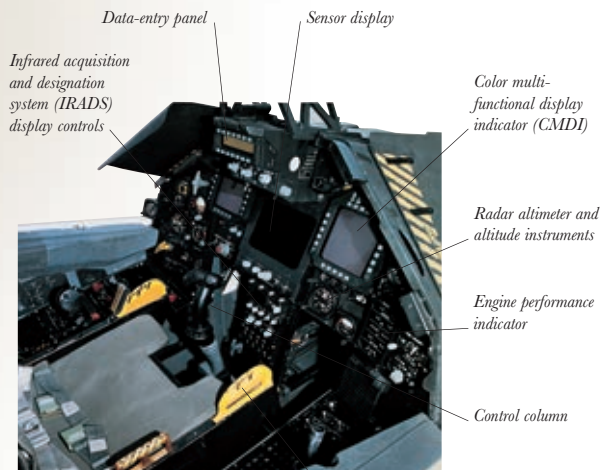


DESERT RANGERS

Unveiled to the public in 1988, the Nighthawk saw its first active service during 1991's Operation Desert Storm. Operating from their base in the Nevada desert, and refueling in midair, F-117As flew over 1,300 sorties and were the only coalition aircraft to strike targets in Baghdad.



VIRTUAL REALITY

The F-117 (modified cockpit shown) was equipped with sophisticated navigation and attack systems integrated into a digital avionics suite that increased mission effectiveness. This included a moving-map display, head-up display, and screen for infrared imagery.

Ejection seat handles

Engine air intakes covered by grilles to screen compressor face from radar

FLIR sensor

Air data sensing probe

Window for forward-looking infrared (FLIR) sighting and targeting unit

Nose wheel

Flat "platypus" slot exhaust jetpipe reduces engine noise and infrared signature

FRONT VIEW

The flat undersurfaces of the F-117A's wing are blended into the fuselage, so the whole underside became a lifting surface. The exterior was almost entirely covered with matte-black radar-absorbent material.

Ruddervators combine functions of rudders and elevators

Composite construction leading edge

SLOWING DOWN

The F-117A had a landing speed of 172mph (227kph) so it needed a drag chute to reduce the length of the landing run.

